

SB62G2 Shuttle XPC

Bonsai powerhouse

Based on the Intel 865G chipset, the Shuttle SB62G2 XPC is a miniature powerhouse. It has a brushed aluminium finish, and stands no taller than half a mini-tower. The screwless cabinet houses an 865G chipset-based custom-made motherboard, which supports a Pentium 4 processor up to 3.2 GHz, and has two memory slots for 400 MHz DDR memory. Cooling for the processor is via a specially designed heat-pipe cooling technology. The bracket that holds devices such as the hard disk is detachable. The necessary cables are provided, and the detailed manual illustrates the cable layout procedures clearly. There's one AGP slot and one PCI slot. The back panel has an onboard LAN connector, four USB 2.0 ports, one Firewire port, one onboard VGA connector and a serial



port. The front has additional USB and Firewire ports. The XPC comes with support for six-channel sound, and optical In/Out for SPDIF connections. In the Content creation and Business Winstone test, the XPC nearly outperformed several recently tested motherboards. The video encoding test took 72 seconds—similar to other 865-based boards. Gaming performance, too, was comparable to that of most 865-based boards.

The XPC is priced at Rs 16,500—an expensive proposition, considering that it's basically just a motherboard in a space-saving cabinet.

SPECIFICATIONS

865G chipset motherboard, support for DDR 400 MHz, six USB 2.0 ports, two Firewire ports, SPDIF-In/Out, proprietary heat pipe cooling, 220 W power supply

Price: Rs 16,500
Contact: Mediatech India
Phone: 022-26361111
Fax: 022- 26312222
E-mail: info@mediatechindia.com
Web site: www.shuttle.com

SB62G2 Shuttle XPC		B
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Microtek ScanMaker 3840

Cheaper, faster, better

The ScanMaker 3840 from Microtek scans at an optical resolution of 2,400 x 1,200 pixels at 65,535 colours, in software interpolated mode. The scanner has a USB interface with three hotkeys for scan, mail and print.

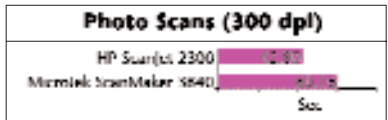
The provided TWAIN driver is not as intuitive as those that come with other scanners;



also, values are predefined. However, there is an advanced mode, from where you can custom-define the resolution, and set brightness and contrast.

The build quality is solid, and performance was decent.

Scanning our text document at 300 dpi took 24.78 seconds. It took a little over three minutes for the same



document at 1,200 dpi. It read the scanned newspaper image using OCR software without a glitch.

The scanner also passed the image quality evaluation test with above-average results. It disappointed in the smoothness test, where the image was a little on the dark side; also, the colour blend in a shadowed area appeared blocky.

Price: Rs 4,999
Contact: Rashi Peripherals
Phone: 022-28221013
Fax: 022-56916609
E-mail: ho@rptechindia.com
Web site: www.microtek.com

The scanner is priced at Rs 4,990, and makes for a good buy wherever scanner use is occasional. We recommend it for document scanning, but not for images.

SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS

1,200 x 2,400 dpi, A4 scan area, USB interface, 48-bit colour depth

Microtek ScanMaker 3840		B
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Hitachi Travelstar 7K60 (60GB 7200rpm laptop hard drive)

Faster, and how!

This 2.5-inch form factor drive gives a much needed boost to laptop performance. We tested the drive with a Zenith 5X Premium notebook, and the scores were compared with those of the 4,200-rpm drive within the laptop. The Travelstar scored much higher, as we expected.

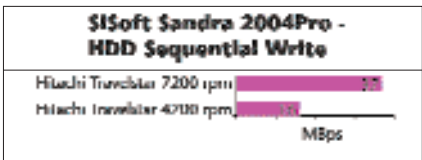
In the SiSoft Sandra 2004 Pro drive benchmark, the Travelstar managed 25,592 drive-indexes, as compared to just 11,724 for the 4200-rpm drive. It also logged 37 MBps sequential read speed and 7 MBps sequential write speed, as compared to 16 MBps and 4 MBps respectively for the 4,200-rpm drive.

This drive is best suited to notebooks that use desktop processors, and also have better graphics chips on board. The Travelstar is also suitable for slim form-factor desktop PCs such as the Dell Optiplex series.

Price: Rs 20,500 plus taxes
Contact: Spectra Innovations Inc
Phone: 011-25737668
Fax: 011-25737668
Web site: www.hitachi.com



The price—Rs 20,500 plus taxes—makes the Travelstar an expensive upgrade, but if you use your laptop for disk-intensive computing needs, this is the drive we recommend. The Travelstar carries a three-year warranty.



SPECIFICATIONS

60 GB, 7,200 rpm, 2.5-inch form factor, ATA6 interface

Hitachi Travelstar 7K60 (60GB 7200rpm laptop hard drive)		B
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	